

Constructivism

Flourishing in the USSR in the 1920s and 1930s, constructivism was the means by which artists and architects intended to create a new Soviet Union, by exploiting modern materials such as steel, concrete and expanses of glass. Principles of constructivism emerged from suprematism, De Stijl and the Bauhaus. Their main aim was to bring the avant-garde into everyday life, but a shortage of funds after the Russian Revolution meant the movement remained more of an ideology than a practical movement, and few designs were built. Vladimir Tatlin (1885–1953), for instance, designed the *Monument to the Third International*, or 'Tatlin's Tower', in Petrograd (St Petersburg) in 1919–20. Though never built, this glass and steel structure was to have been a fantastic, 400-metre (1,312-ft) double spiral with a revolving cone and cylinders, to serve as headquarters of the Comintern. Konstantin Melnikov (1890–1974) designed and built the Soviet Pavilion for the 1925 Decorative Arts Exposition in Paris: a dynamic, cantilevered structure with rooms designed by Alexander Rodchenko (1891–1956).



Mosselprom Building in Moscow, N.D. Strukov, 1917–25